

Another First For Samsung

Samsung unveiled the world's first wireless broadband handsets—called WiBro mobile handsets—at the Asia Pacific Economic Co-operation Summit. WiBro prepares to be fully implemented and utilised next year. Samsung put on display both the mobile phone-type H1000 and the PDA-type M8000.



Microsoft Says Yes To Supercomputing

Software giant Microsoft has released the second beta of its mainstream technical computing software or supercomputing software, Windows Compute Cluster 2003. This is the company's first foray into supercomputing software, where it is up against open source competitors such as Linux.

Microsoft

Enter

Shaun
Singer

Shaun gave a new dimension to Indipop with his songs, right from his first release *Q-Funk* to the hugely popular *Tanha Dil*. Is the singer tech-savvy too? Read on...

What does technology mean to you?

Technology means progress. It helps us achieve what would otherwise be beyond our reach. It enhances the way we live and work, and it has also made us dependent on it—and life *sans* technology is now unthinkable. Gadgets such as the mobile phone that were earlier a luxury have now become a necessity—such is the growth of technology in our life and society.

How do you use technology in your daily activities?

I primarily use technology for calling people. I also use e-mail. However, I prefer to maintain a fine balance between using and over-using technology.

What gadgets do you own?

I own a number of gadgets, but I rarely have the time to use them. A Motorola Razr is the cell phone of my choice—it's neat and sleek. My earlier phone tried my patience. I also have a Hitachi DVD camera which can record directly onto DVDs.

How has technology influenced your career?

Technology hasn't played a big part in my career. Admittedly, it has made recording and playback convenient. Personally, I would never use devices such as pitch correcting machines for recording.

SHOULD WE CALL IT 'SONYWARE'?

Windows Labels XCP Spyware

Sony thought they were just protecting their music from being ripped and stolen, but a Windows programming expert by the name of Mark Russinovich recently unearthed something dirty. Used as a protection system for their audio CDs, Sony's XCP system has turned out to be the darling of a number of spyware and virus writers. This support to malware provided by the copy protection system, albeit inadvertently, has resulted in Sony staring at a number of class action suits and other legal hassles.

The XCP system is controversial because it uses techniques more often seen

in computer viruses to hide itself on users' machines. Specifically, XCP uses a 'root kit' to conceal itself deep inside Windows.

A root kit is a set of tools used by an intruder after hacking a computer. These tools can help the attacker maintain his access to the system and use it for malicious purposes. It could also be a hacker security tool that captures passwords and message traffic to and from a computer, or a collection of tools that allows a hacker enter into a system.

Subsequently, Microsoft labelled the system as malware, and has announced that further

updates of its anti-spyware kits would have XCP removal tools!

According to Microsoft, the XCP software qualified as spyware under the "objective criteria" Microsoft uses to assess potentially malicious programs. The company, in its corporate blog, also recently said, "Root-kits have a clearly negative impact on not only the security, but also the reliability and performance of the users' systems."

There also has been news of virus writers taking advantage of the XCP system to hide their malicious pieces of code. The resulting negative publicity has meant that Sony has suspended the manufacture of audio CDs with the XCP protection system.

To add to Sony's woes, amateur sleuths have claimed that the code used to create XCP, which guards CDs against copyright infringement, itself has been culled from the code written by Jon Johansen to circumvent DRM (Digital Rights Management) on DVDs! Sony had outsourced the coding work for XCP to First4Internet, a British software firm. Now the sleuths claim that First4Internet lifted pieces of code that are covered by the Free Software Foundation's LGPL, or Lesser General Public License. This license covers the author's



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